



UHLB2122

PROFESSIONAL COMMUNICATION SKILLS 1

SECTION 55

GROUP 2B

WRITING REPORT:

**TITLE : BRIDGING THE GAP: THE ROLE OF EXPERIENTIAL LEARNING IN
HIGHER EDUCATION FOR CAREER READINESS**

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SECTION 55

1.0 INTRODUCTION

In today's fast-changing workplace, graduates are expected to be ready for work immediately after graduation, but students still lack the practical experience, although universities provide good theoretical knowledge. The gap between academic preparation and real-world expectations has widened. Experiential learning closes this gap by allowing students to apply classroom knowledge directly to work and build important soft skills in different working environments. Celio et al. (2011) mention that experiential learning will improve academic performance and boost students' confidence and employability. Besides, the National Association of Colleges and Employers (NACE, 2025) also reports that students with more experiential learning usually get more job offers and higher starting salaries. However, many students still graduate with minimal hands-on experience. Sharma and Naidu (2023) point out that traditional classroom-based learning alone does not prepare students with the practical skills needed today. Okolie (2022) also highlights that structured internships and mentorship improve readiness, but students still have problems in accessing these opportunities. This report explores factors of career unreadiness. It also argues that academic education by itself is not enough and suggests three solutions, which are structured internships and industry mentorship, including real company problems in coursework, and giving academic credit for community-based projects.

2.0 CONTRIBUTING FACTORS TO CAREER UNREADINESS

While university education provides essential theoretical foundations, it is insufficient on its own to ensure students are fully prepared for their future careers. This section presents the main factors that contribute to the issue of graduate unreadiness, offering a counter-argument to the idea that academic qualifications alone prepare students for the demands of the workforce.

2.1 LACK OF PRACTICAL EXPERIENCE

A primary reason leading to career unreadiness in university graduates is the lack of access to structured experiential learning throughout their studies. Though some students manage to acquire internships, many are short-term, unstructured, or even unrelated to particular fields of study. Spanjaard et al. (2018) mentioned that such limited experience is still not enough for graduates to be familiar with basic workplace protocols, technology tools, or working environment. Furthermore, universities often emphasise exams, theoretical knowledge, and memorization skills. Because of this, students do not get enough chances to build important skills such as teamwork, doing hands-on projects, and skills to solve real-life problems. This

mismatch between the achievements in academia and the needs in the workplace makes graduates unprepared for working.

2.2 IMPACTS OF THE PROBLEM

Graduates who do not undergo real-world experiential learning tend to struggle in applying theoretical knowledge at work. This makes them feel less confident, cannot perform well in interviews, and need more time to adapt to full-time jobs because previously involved in an unstructured and short internship. It can also stop students from learning soft skills like teamwork, leadership, communication, and problem-solving. Celio et al. (2011) pointed out that even students who achieve high grades in academic work can struggle in fast-paced work without the critical soft skills. This is one reason why many graduates perform well in university but perform poorly in practical work, which in turn affects their employability. On the other hand, students who have experience with experiential learning, according to the National Association of Colleges and Employers (NACE, 2025), have higher chances of getting offered employment as well as better starting salaries.

3.0 POSSIBLE SOLUTIONS

This section elaborates on the three possible solutions to the problem.

3.1 STRUCTURED INTERNSHIPS AND INDUSTRY MENTORSHIP

The first suggested solution highlights the importance of creating well-structured internship and mentorship programs through effective industry-university collaborations. The programs must go beyond observational learning, where the student should be placed with meaningful roles with the responsibility of performing practical work using real tools, and receive guidance and feedback frequently from experienced professionals. For instance, Sharma and Naidu (2023) reported that students who were involved in industry practice like Failure Mode and Effects Analysis (FMEA) became more confident and were more ready for full-time job placements. A properly designed internship program not only delivers technical skills but also provides networking opportunities and inculcates professional ethics. The main benefit of this strategy is that the graduates gain practical exposure along with confidence. However, the implementation of this solution is not easy because it requires extensive time, effort, and continuous commitment from both industry partners. This could be why thoughtful planning and support from both sides are crucial to making this a lasting and inclusive solution.

3.2 AUTHENTIC COMPANY PROBLEMS FOR CLASSROOM PROJECTS

Another powerful solution is the involvement of real company problems as classroom projects. It is a teaching approach that can be done through collaborations between educators

and professionals to introduce real case studies, operational problems, or real data sets for students to explore and solve. Solving real company problems helps students develop their soft skills in the classroom environment because this approach converts theoretical knowledge from textbooks to practice-based skills. Spanjaard et al. (2018) also emphasise that these practical applications let students feel more prepared for their future careers by enhancing engagement and encouraging deeper learning. One outstanding advantage of this approach is its scalability; every student in a course can take part without the need for separate internships. However, to ensure success, the project must be planned carefully to guarantee that the problems maintain academic quality and that students are provided with proper support from professionals to perform the tasks effectively.

3.3 SCHOLARLY CREDIT FOR COMMUNITY-BASED PROJECTS

The third suggested solution is giving academic credit for student involvement in community-based projects. Universities can collaborate with non-governmental organizations (NGOs), local governments, or social enterprises so that students can apply their in-class knowledge to solve specific social or environmental problems. Celio et al. (2011) noted that this kind of experiential learning deepens academic understanding and helps promote students' civic participation and personal growth. This approach is especially relevant to students who have limited access to traditional internships due to geographical, financial, or personal reasons. In addition, it also challenges the idea of academic success by acknowledging social contributions alongside scholarly attainment. Considering that the outcomes of community projects may vary depending on different contexts and the scope of the projects. So, it is important for higher education to create a fair evaluation system to guarantee the effectiveness of this approach.

4.0 CONCLUSION

Briefly, most university graduates are having it tough to get into the job market due to the lack of experience that they can acquire while still in university. The report detailed why this is the case and the implications, and it proposed three practical solutions, which are improving internship programs through industry partnership, involving real company problems in course assignments, and awarding academic credits to community-based experiential learning. These solutions will arm the student with academic and practical knowledge to handle the workforce. Going forward, universities must take proactive steps to integrate more experiential learning into their curriculum. Through partnership and appreciation of different modes of practical involvement, higher-level education can prepare graduates to have successful careers. This, ultimately, will result in an effective and diverse workforce, which drives national growth.

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